

scripts/check-fixture-freshness.sh — User Guide

Last verified: 2026-07-02 (synthetic-fixture marker exemption added) **Inheritance:** HelixConstitution §11.4.18 (script documentation mandate)

Overview

Stub doc generated from the script's in-source header comment. See scripts/check-fixture-freshness.sh for canonical behavior. This stub exists so the CM-SCRIPT-DOCS-SYNC pre-push gate (.github.com/pre-push Check 9) starts gating modifications to this script.

The script's own header documentation (verbatim):

```
scripts/check-fixture-freshness.sh – block stale tracker fixtures.
```

```
Per the SP-3a plan Task 5.18 + the developer guide §4 testing
requirements. Fixtures named with a YYYY-MM-DD date in the
filename
are considered "fresh" if the date is <30 days old (no warning),
"stale" if 30-60 days old (warn), and "expired" if >60 days old
(block – exit non-zero).
```

Sixth Law clause 1 ("same surfaces the user touches") implies that parsers must be tested against HTML that resembles what the user actually sees today. Trackers change their HTML structure; an old fixture is a green-test-against-stale-shape bluff.

Synthetic-fixture exemption (added 2026-07-02)

The freshness rule targets **live-capture** fixtures — HTML saved from the real tracker, whose shape drifts as the tracker changes markup (the "green test against a stale live shape" bluff). It does **not** apply to **synthetic** fixtures: author-authored parser-robustness inputs (empty result set, malformed row, variable-column layout, missing fields, minimal representative rows) whose

shape is deliberately fixed to exercise one parser branch. "Refresh from the live tracker" is meaningless for those — there is no live page that emits a deliberately-malformed row.

A fixture is exempt from the freshness check iff it carries an in-file marker matching `HAND-CRAFTED FIXTURE` or `lava-fixture: synthetic` (case-insensitive). The convention already existed in-tree (e.g. `login/failure-wrong-password` open with `<!-- HAND-CRAFTED FIXTURE ... -->`); the gate now **honors** it rather than blocking author-declared synthetics. The tiny kinozal/nmclub unit fixtures were given the same marker (their live verification runs via the `-PrealTrackers *RealNetworkDownloadTest crown-jewel` runs).

Anti-bluff (§6.J): the marker is a human-auditable in-file comment — a reviewer opens the file and confirms it is genuinely hand-crafted. Live captures carry **no** marker and stay freshness-checked. Adding the marker to a real live capture to dodge a refresh would be a §6.J bluff, plainly visible in the diff. Falsifiability: delete the marker from a synthetic fixture and the gate re-blocks it.

Usage

See the script's in-source comment block (above) for canonical usage examples.

Maintenance

When this script is modified, update this document in the same commit (CM-SCRIPT-DOCS-SYNC requires it). Per §11.4.18, the documentation **MUST** stay in sync with the codebase — no doc may be out of sync with its script.

Cross-references

- `scripts/check-fixture-freshness.sh` — the script itself
- `docs/helix-constitution-gates.md` — gate inventory
- `HelixConstitution Constitution.md §11.4.18` (the mandate)
- `Lava CLAUDE.md §6.AD` (HelixConstitution Inheritance)